

THE MARCH TOWARD Civil Rights

THE FIGHT FOR RACIAL EQUALITY

In the US, the Civil Rights Movement of the mid-20th century challenged the Jim Crow system. The system, named after a 19th-century minstrel show that portrayed African Americans in a derogatory manner, made people of color second-class citizens by segregating them from their white peers. At the same time, the Civil Rights Movement reflected 1950s notions of gender roles, with men assuming leadership positions and negotiating with the white establishment, and women working behind-the-scenes—organizing, printing leaflets, and fundraising. Rosa Parks, the only woman at the first National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) meeting in 1943, took the minutes. Thousands of women laid the groundwork of the movement, but many went unrecognized despite their contributions.

Black women had a history of activism. Ida Wells Barnett, Mary McLeod Bethune, and Mary Church Terrell mobilized black women to agitate for political rights and improved social welfare for African Americans, despite a hostile post-slavery environment. Early in the Civil Rights Movement, black women took bold stances. Pauli Murray was arrested in 1940 for refusing to move to the back of a bus, and as a law student led a sit-in

that desegregated a restaurant. Her legal writing influenced the case that led to the landmark 1954 Supreme Court decision to desegregate schools, which had previously kept black and white students “separate but equal.” Murray crusaded against Jim Crow laws as well as gender discrimination, which she termed Jane Crow. In 1955, lawyer Dovey Johnson Roundtree challenged segregation laws for interstate bus travel and won.

Disobedience and protest

As the movement gathered steam, South Carolina teacher Septima Clark developed voting rights workshops for black citizens. Chicago-born Diane Nash resisted Jim Crow in Tennessee; jailed in 1960 after a sit-in, she became a force for the Student Non-Violent Coordinating Committee (SNCC). Activist Ella Baker guided SNCC, and recruited two white women, Jane Stembridge and Connie Curry, to harness black and white students’ passion, creating an army of civil disobedience protesters to encourage black voter registration. With support from SNCC, farmer Fannie Lou Hamer became a politician despite her limited education, and argued for the

Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party to have seats at the 1964 Democratic Convention in place of an all-white group of Southern Democrats. Despite their successes in Civil Rights activism, women were excluded from the spotlight at the 1963 March on Washington, one of the movement’s biggest protests. Women’s pleas to play a prominent, public role in the march were ignored.

► Activist behind bars

Angela Davis, a communist and associate of the radical Black Panthers, was arrested in 1970 in connection with a jailbreak and murder case. Her 18-month imprisonment set off a national movement to free both Davis and other political prisoners. Davis was acquitted in 1972.

